

placing the seedlings. Fit your seedlings with a brassica collar (see right) to deter cabbage root fly, which will attack the plants' roots. At all stages of growth, cabbages will be irresistible to birds and cabbage white butterflies, so put mesh or netting over your crop.

CROP CARE

Weed seedlings thoroughly. Water regularly, daily, if necessary, when young, and then once a week when plants are more established. As cabbages grow, you will need to earth up the soil around them to support the weight of their growing heads. Trim off any dead outer leaves. Apply a high-nitrogen fertilizer or



Net cabbages to deter butterflies.

organic liquid feed to summer-sown cabbages in winter; feed fall-sown cabbages in spring.

HARVESTING

Spring or early summer cabbages can be harvested when they are still loose and leafy, before their leaves develop into a firm head; these are known as “spring

DISEASES

Cabbages are under threat from diseases such as downy and powdery mildew and white blister, but there are few as serious as clubroot—a disease to which all brassicas are prone. This fungus attacks the plants' roots, rotting and eventually killing them. There is no cure—so good garden hygiene, crop rotation, and digging up and destroying infected plants are absolutely essential.



Plants cannot be cured of clubroot. It can persist in the soil for up to 20 years.